

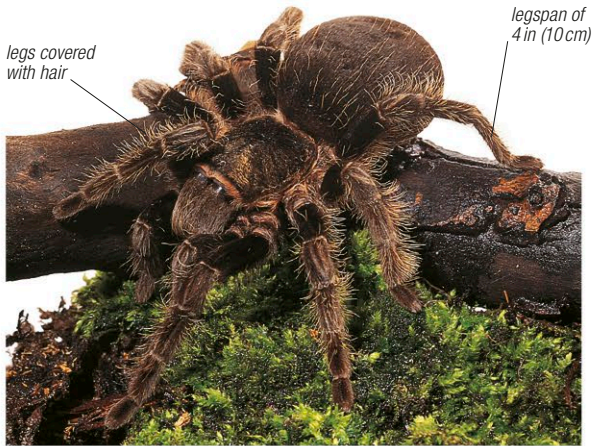
Family Theraphosidae

Tarantulas

Occurrence 950 spp. worldwide, especially in subtropical and tropical regions; in ground burrows, trees

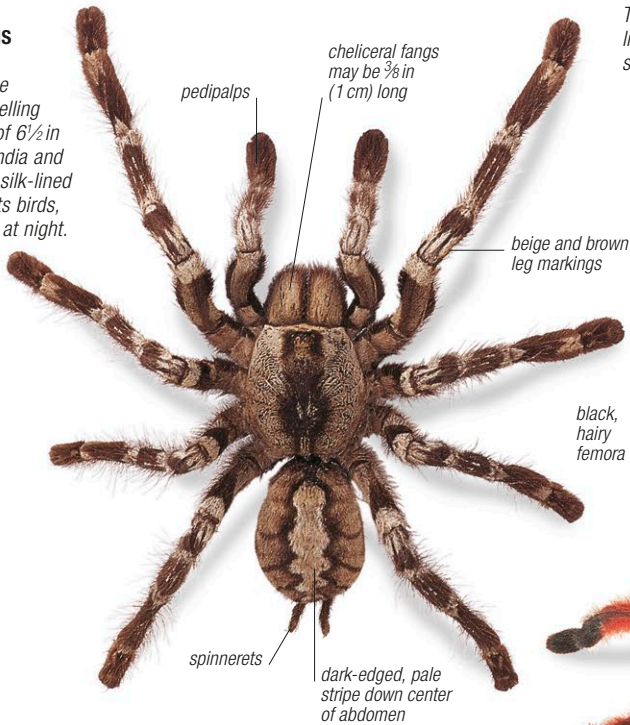


The name tarantula was originally applied to a wolf spider from southern Europe (see opposite), but nowadays it is far more often used for this family. These are the giants of the spider world, with bodies up to 4¼ in (12 cm) long, and a legspan of up to 11 in (28 cm). Their bodies and legs are covered in bristly hairs, and their coloration varies from pale brown to black, with markings in pink, brown, red, or black. They are mygalomorphs, like funnel-web spiders (see p.589), with fangs that move up and down. When threatened, a tarantula will display its downward-pointing fangs. The large size of tarantulas has led to the belief that their bites are fatal but only some species are venomous; in fact, the venomous species are often relatively small. Tarantulas are nocturnal hunters,



relying on their large size to subdue prey, which include small vertebrates such as frogs, lizards, and birds. They crush their prey with their large fangs, pour digestive juices over the body, and then suck up the resulting liquid. Females lay a batch of eggs in a burrow. An egg sac can be the size of a golf ball and contain about 1,000 eggs. Spiderlings stay in the burrow until their first molt, and then disperse to find food and make their own burrows. Several species of this family live for 10–30 years, and some are kept as pets.

POECILOtheria regalis
The tiger or Indian ornamental spider is the world's largest tree-dwelling spider, with a legspan of 6½ in (17 cm). It is found in India and Sri Lanka. It hides in a silk-lined retreat by day and hunts birds, lizards, and arthropods at night.

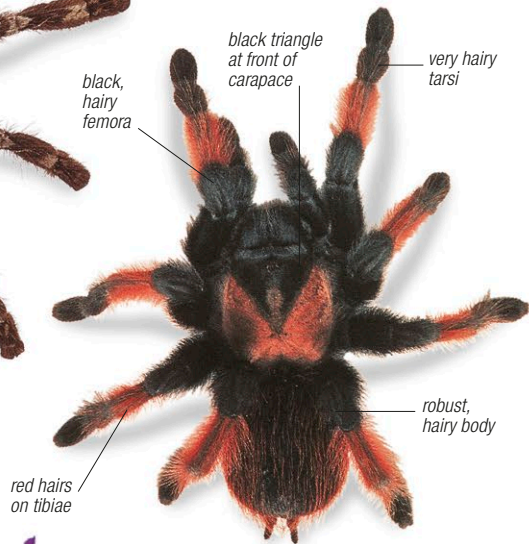


GRAMMOSTOLA ROSEA
Found in South America, especially in Chile, the ground-living Chilean rose is one of the species most commonly kept as a pet because of its docile nature.



BRACHYPELMA VAGANS
The Mexican red-rumped tarantula is a ground-living species that hunts at night. It is found in semidesert and arid regions of Central America.

BRACHYPELMA EMILIA
The Mexican red-legged tarantula lives in burrows in desert and semidesert regions of Central America. It kicks up the hairs of its abdomen as a defensive reaction.



Family Thomisidae

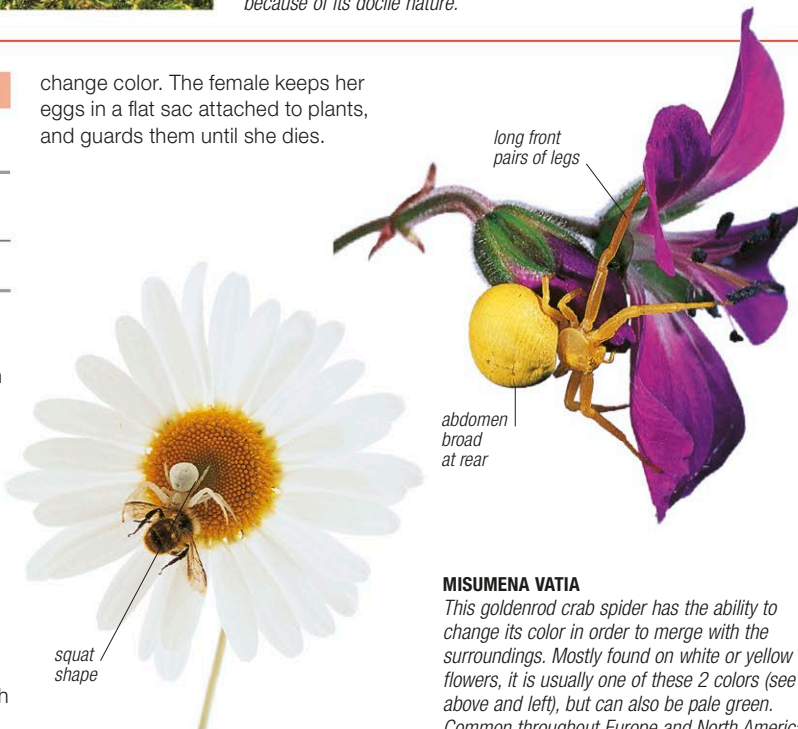
Crab spiders

Occurrence 2,150 spp. worldwide; in meadows, gardens, on flowers, other parts of plants, tree bark



The common name derives from these spiders' characteristic crablike sideways movement (although they can also move forward and backward) and usually squat shape; however, some species are elongated. Crab spiders range from 5/32 to 1/2 in (4–14 mm) in length. The carapace is nearly circular, and the abdomen is short, often blunt ended. The first 2 pairs of legs, used to seize prey, are larger and spiner than the other 2 pairs. Crab spiders often ambush insects landing on flowers—species that do so have very powerful venom, which can easily kill a bee much larger than themselves. Many species are colored white, bright pink, or yellow, to match the flowers, and a few can

change color. The female keeps her eggs in a flat sac attached to plants, and guards them until she dies.



MISUMENA VATIA
This goldenrod crab spider has the ability to change its color in order to merge with the surroundings. Mostly found on white or yellow flowers, it is usually one of these 2 colors (see above and left), but can also be pale green. Common throughout Europe and North America, it can tackle large prey such as butterflies and bees. The female is much larger than the male.

Family Philodromidae

Running crab spiders

Occurrence 600 species worldwide; in meadows, gardens, on flowers, other parts of plants, tree bark



These small to medium spiders are generally colored with browns or grays, and have a body covered in long hairs. They were formerly classified among Thomisidae (left), but are now understood to be more distantly related to them. They are less inclined to ambush their prey—like true crab spiders—and instead catch them while on the run.



TIBELLUS OBLONGUS
Widespread all across the northern hemisphere, this spider can be found in a variety of damp grassland habitats.